

Cyber Confined

(???) Chapter 1 (Cyber Revolution)

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I walk down the streets for the first time I'd expect to in peace... yeah, I was way over my head to believe the city would just come to peace. Around me people are broken into rallies; they are attacking each other. People have been living for years with Mort's Chip, but now— it's as if they are unable to live and get along without it. Could Mort have been right in his doings? No. I shake the thought from within my head. Our past existed just fine without any Chips why couldn't it now? My face contorts in disgust over everything happening ever since Mort's removal of power. The streets are not even safe and they feel as if they may even be more dangerous than they were before, even with the DRE on the streets. If people keep this up they're will be no more Ascendedx and no Ascendedx means no city for them to reside in. How do the smaller towns out in the depths do it? Could it be their size or is it because they've always lived without a Chip to control them?

(- - -)

Mort will come back in an AI form and cause major chaos and trying to gain control to turn everyone on Ender and his friends.

MORT HAS RETURNED

A new law has been put in place. Everyone will be required to get Nanos injected into their blood. They are designed to keep our community healthier as well as promoting more rapid healing from injuries. My heart races as the announcement finishes. No it can't be. Nanos, injected into our blood. Mort, he's dead— it can't be..." I remember how calm Mort seemed over his death. No, impossible. But to me it makes no difference if it's Mort Phobus or not; Whoever has taken power would be making a mistake to bring such a horrendous device back, and I will not be allowing myself to have this new procedure anytime soon. I need to distract myself, "Hey Imperia," I force a smile on my face, "Would you like to go check out the new bakery just down the block?"

Her face brightens in enlightenment, "I'd love to!"

It is such a relief to have her back here with me. I don't think I could survive one day without her if I had to, I let out a sigh, especially not after what Mort did.

"Ender are you alright?" she asks in concern.

"Yeah... I'm alright."

"No..." she presses, "you are bothered by something."

Well, I mean the world has gone crazy, I barely made it here alive. The news is reporting riots in the streets. I don't think anyone is safe anymore. What will I do if something happened to Imperia? The thought of losing her is too much to bare.

"What?" I ask.

"Your so tense, you look like you got hit by a truck. Relax, you know you can count on me, I won't leave you alone. Not only am I here with you — I'll protect you as long as I'm able."

"Thanks, Imperia."

"Let's go get some dessert and then we can head home."

"Sounds good to me."

The air is thick with tension, as the sun sets the temperature drops rapidly. The atmosphere grows colder by the minute. I am glad I grabbed a jacket when we left the house.

We walk slowly down the street towards the bakery. We pass a few shops, most of which are closed due to the fact that people are looting stores for supplies. I notice that many of the buildings have their windows shattered. I wonder how long it will take until all the windows are broken.

I feel someone watching us from behind and spin around and see a man standing next to the building across the street. He is dressed in black, with a hood covering his face.

"You two shouldn't be out at night," he says in a low voice.

Imperia looks over her shoulder. "Who are you?" she asks.

He raises a hand, and points at me. "He's the kid with special powers..."

"No point in running, We've already captured your friend."

Chapter Enders Parents

Chapter A (Cyber Revolution)

I walk down the streets for the first time I'd expect to in peace... yeah, I was way over my head to believe the city would just come to peace. Around me people are broken into rallies; they are attacking each other. People have been living for years with Mort's Chip, but now— it's as if they are unable to live and get along without it. Could Mort have been right in his doings? No. I shake the thought from within my head. Our past existed just fine without any Chips why couldn't it now? My face contorts in disgust over everything happening ever since Mort's removal of power. The streets are not even safe and they feel as if they may even be more dangerous than they were before, even with the DRE on the streets. If people keep this up they're will be no more Ascenedx and no Ascenedx means no city for them to reside in. How do the smaller towns out in the depths do it? Could it be their size or is it because they've always lived without a Chip to control them?

The air is thick with tension, as the sun sets the temperature drops rapidly. The atmosphere grows colder by the minute. I am glad I grabbed a jacket when I left our apartment. I can't believe I never thought to go see my parents. They should be different right? Now that their implants are no longer active. The emotions are trying to run through a crowded room and conflict one another as I approach the front door. My arm extends to knock... no answer. I'm about to knock a second time when the thudding of footsteps comes down the sidewalk.

Goose bumps form on my skin and I rapidly pivot on my heels. My voice isn't responding while he is dressed in black; a hood covering his face.

"You shouldn't be out at night," he says in a low voice.

"Who are you?"

"We have your parents and we need your help."

I am unsure of which side he may be on, "How do I know your not lying?"

"You don't... but your going to have to trust me. The president has issued protection for you and your families as payment for something you may only be able to perform at with the necessary skill levels."

(- - -)

I'm sitting in the back of the van now, there's not a window to be seen back here. so we could be almost anywhere in the city by this point. I feel like the vehicle has been moving for hours, I guess it could be because there's nothing to do back here either; I wish I could sit still haha. I let out a breath of relief when the vehicle stops rumbling. I assume this means we've reached our destination.

Light floods into the back of the vehicle. I assume this means we are inside, presumably a garage of some sort. When I step outside of the vehicle I realize this is no ordinary garage, but a large, rectangular complex with a garage-like entrance. There were no vehicles. Instead, there was just a long, wide hallway, curving inwards. The only other thing that seemed out of place was there were at least a dozen people in this space, all of them sitting in front of consoles, waiting. Wait... this is no garage— it's a laboratory! The door we just drove through wasn't meant to be a garage at all. The doors to bring in heavy equipment!

In my absence, I fail to notice the man approach, "Sorry for such a short notice."

I jump, "Ahh! You scared me."

"Didn't mean to do that either," he smiles, "Oh! And before I forget. Your here because the government has deemed it necessary. This is top secret information, and if you already known Ascendex is under a cyber attack... we're going to be so screwed"

I see why they're trying to keep it a secret. If people knew about this they'd be thrown into a state of panic, which of course could probably have the ability to tear us apart. By keeping this information private, they've managed to maintain control.

"Until recently we have had this attack under control, hence why you see so many people here. They're trying to keep the hackers attacks at bay to protect the public. Today brings different circumstances, we've nearly lost control of our defenses and they've almost penetrated through," he sighs, "Which is why we've brought you here. With your skills we were hoping you could use one of those immersive headsets which we've connected to the internet in hopes you could help us keep the hackers at bay."

"Now am I supposed to help? I'm just—"

"As much as I hate to say... your are best option," he pauses, "there is no way we are going to be faster than these hackers for long without your unquie abilities."

"Wait! What?!" I scream, "I can't connect to the internet!" I look towards Imperia, "It's too dangerous!"

"Wrong. With our ranks, we'll have eye on you at all times. We'll be ready to serve the connection if anything may backfire."

We have almost no say in the matter, it's begining to sound like we are gonig to have to help whether we think it's a good idea or not. I mean they've already told us the information. If I refuse I'm willing to bet I'll be bidding my time in isolation instead, "Fine... I'll do it."

The man slaps his hands together, "That's what I like to hear!"

The man begins walking, gesturing for me to follow him down the hallway. He leads me into a room you'd assumed used to be an office. In the office is a single chair in the middle of the room with a small desk in front of it. And then a longer desk to the side of the room where it looks to be a nurse is sitting.

"Be my guest," the man gestures to the chair.

I lower myself in the chair which is definently not the most comfortable chair I've sat in.

"Oh," the man adds, "the chair may not be the best, it's designed for prolonged periods of time."

"Here is your headset," he's holding a headset out to me.

My insides ingnite and I'm sure I may spontaneously combust at any moment, it's like a match has been droped in the center of the deep pit in my stomach.

The headset clicks onto my head, absorbing me in the darkness of rows upon rows of green text.

"Can you hear me?" a voice says

"Yes, are you hear to guide me?" I ask.

"You bet it!" he exclaims, "now I'm going to need you to do something for me. We've set up a few computers we'd like to run a test on. Your job will be to hack them! Good luck!"

I am now all alone. They really do expect me to do all their hacking for them, the one thing I would've rather not gotten dragged into. I focus my inter thoughts on what I

believe to be the computers they intend for me to hack in the facility. *Display text*, I think. Right now those computers should be showing the text "you are hacked" at this moment.

I hear the voice again, "Good, now shut those computers down."

I send a command through my mind, and the computers all become disabled. It's what I do best with nearly every computer.

"Outstanding! We'll be pulling you out now, the man wants to speak with you."

With the flash of light I find myself sitting back in the chair.

"Stupendous work!" the man pats me on the head, "You'll be of great use to us."

"Why are you making me do this?" I blurt.

"Ahh... Well think of it as providing protection for your country," he says simply, "Now we don't want you tired do we? I'll show you to your room!"

The man swiftly exits the room and I follow him. It's not like I have any other options right now. He leads me into a room which appears to be far nicer than my bedroom at home. The walls are plaided in silver and I get a whole Queen size bed to myself!

"Here you are," he claps his hands together, "We hope you find it suitable."

"It's marvelous!" I say without thinking and the man smiles.

Chapter B (Cyber Revolution)

I am in the virtual world and I'm hacking for real this time. I've been at it for a few hours now, listening to the man commands as to what I need to do. So far I've already taken out 50 of the enemies computers. I feel a tingling on in the back of my head— the code suddenly disappears. *What happened?* I quickly taken in my new surroundings. Not good. I am trapped within a cell. *Turn off, I command.* I try harder, why can't I penetrate the code? As soon as I try to change anything the code rewrites itself. Must go faster, I grunt. I try again and again faster each time, but even my best efforts are far from passing through. Then I know why. They told me they were watching for any backfire from me. They completely overlooked the enemy. The enemy almost literally walked in.

"Help!" I shout... No response.

My chest feels like a prison as my heart beats as if it will erupt out of it at any moment, "What can I do, what can I do..."

There's a flash of light and another figure appears. I wait for my eyes to adjust— It's Benjo.

Cautiously I approach the figure. "Benjo?"

"Wait, where am it? Ender why are you here?" he begins to come to his senses.

"I think we were—" Another bolt of lightning interrupts me, "Imperia Is that you?"

"Y-yes. Where am I," she whimpers, "I was trying to protect everyone's data from hackers—" she claps her hands over her mouth, "Oh my gosh, I wasn't supposed to say that!"

"It's okay, I believe we were all working on the same task," I sigh, "What matter's right now is how we are going to get out."

"No way?! Benjo you have the power to control computers with your touch too?" she yelps, "How come you never told me?"

"Actually I've done my best to tell no one," he claims, "I didn't want anyone to know... to my knowledge I've never told anyone about my powers," Benjo adds, "I don't even understand how they figured it out."

"Now that's settled," Imperia's timid, "What do we do now?"

"I don't know, It appears we are inside some kind of cell."

"Yeah like that's obvious, couldn't we just—" She begins.

"Nope. Already tried that, the codes impenetrable."

"Come on!" she cries.

I close the distance between us, "Imperia, we'll be okay. I'll find a way to get us out."

She looks up at me and her lips twitch into a small smile, "Your sure?"

"Absolutely," I say confidently.

I bring my hands together, "Since we can't penetrate the code. We'll just have to do this the old fashion way."

Ben nods, "Okay everyone start looking. If you spot anything of use, bring it to the middle of the room."

"Oh, I see your trying to escape?" a man lets off a maniac laugh, "We don't want that now do we?"

Clinking sounds throughout the room. Something cold snaps onto my wrist. I look down and I am sent into a panic. Chains weigh down my arms, binding me to the floor. Just then a door opens in the room, greeting me with a face you'd never hoped to be staring into. I could identify his face anywhere.

"WAIT!!" I growl, "b-but you are dead and I was even there to watch it!"

"Yes... I did die, haha" I shiver as he laughs, "y-you... really thought—" he bursts into Demonic laughter, "oh your funny! I just uploaded myself into another body."

I choke on my own words as my insides burn, "y-you can't—"

"Oh but I can! Enjoy your stay hehe!"

I glance around the room, "are you guys alright?" moments pass before a response comes.

"I don't feel the best, but I'll be fine" Imperia whispers.

"Same here," calls Benjo.

Energy is running through my veins. I know we'll escape. I feel around in the darkness. C'mon there has to be something I can use. My hand brushes against something cold. The object is almost out of reach as I strain my arm to reach my objective. My hand closes on something cold. I strain to see the object in the darkness, it has a pointed end and its rust crumbles into my hand. I guess its worth a shot and I carefully insert the old nail into the lock and start playing with the nail inside. I slide the nail up and down, back and forth, until I hear one pin "click." I continue the technique for another 5 minutes. After three more "clicks" As I exhale, I get a sense of relief. However, it does not last long; I have only managed to loosen one of the cuffs and the others still locking me down. Before I turn my attention to picking the other lock, I slip the free cuff back onto my wrist, leaving it a little slack. I focus on the other cuff, picking the lock to free myself.

"I got an arm out," I whisper.

"How?" Imperia responds.

"I found—"

The sound of a metal door creaking is followed by a influx of light. My eyes have gotten so used to the dark and I can barely make out the form of the bulky man entering the room.

He patrols through the room and I hold my breath as the man gives a quick glance to my cuffs before grunting his approval. The man steps back outside into the hallway sucking the light back away. I wait a few moments before returning to the cuffs. In total it took me 9 minutes to pick both locks. With both of my cuffs off I still need to free Imperia from hers and Benjo from theirs.

"Imperia, do you think you can pick the locks on your own?"

Hesitating she whispers, "I can try, but . . . I have never actually picked a lock before."

I believe in her so I quickly slip from my cuffs to pass the nail over to her. I think it will be far riskier if I have to fully remove my cuffs long enough to help her myself. She begins working her way through the locks. She's at it for 15 minutes before the click finally comes.

"Put the handcuff back on. Leave it loose enough so you can slip out later," I whisper. Another 10 minutes pass — she is out. Imperia does the same with her cuffs loosely refitting them as she hands the nail over to Benjo.

"Alright... we have to get out of this cellar. Do you see anyway out other than the door?" I ask.

"Yes, there is a grate a little to my right." "If we can get it loose, we might be able to crawl through it," she says quietly.

"Are there any screws holding it down?" I ask.

"Yes, 4 and one's already missing."

I swiftly slip the handcuffs from my wrists, before crawling over to the grate, Benjo stays where he is. No need to have too many of us lose. The grate is held by 3 flat head screws, I can work with that. "

Can I see the nail?" I asks while holding my hand out.

She lowers the nail into my hand and her hand stays in contact with mine momentary. We are going to need to do this fast as I painfully I twist the first screw out with the nail. I have only one word to describe the process, tedious. A warm liquid oozes down my arm, but I continue on anyway.

"Here," I hand the screw I just took out to Imperia so we can work together to get the last 2 screws out more efficiently.

As soon as the final screw is out, I drop the old nail in my pocket in case for good measures and give the grate a tug. The grate came out effortlessly, and I was worried it wouldn't budge. I lower myself into the grate, while Imperia comes down next. As Benjo comes down he pulls the grate back over on his way down.

"Good thinking," I whisper, "We need to stay unterly quiet, because I am almost certain this grate is an amazing carrier of sound."

We crawl, creeping our way along the shaft. Benjo holds up the rear of the pack, While I'm still up front. Doing this silently is a challenge, it's so hard to inch along while your in a life or death situation.

A faint glow makes a bend in the shaft visible up ahead. As we progress, the glow becomes slivers of light, another grate! I inch my way assiduously towards the grate

before carefully leaning down and resting my face against the cold metal. My eyes take a moment to adjust, before I am able to make out a room through the grate. The ground is carpeted and resting in the middle of the room is a heavy metal desk. Positioned on the right side of the room is a window!

"Look!" I exclaim a little too loudly, "Our way out!"

"What is it?" she mouths holding a finger up to her mouth.

"It's a room," I gasp, "there's a window!" Taking this grate off is going to be tricky. Why do the screws have to be on the outside?!

"There is just no way for me to remove those screws," I grown, "my hands nowhere near to being able to squeeze through."

"Can I try?" Imperia urges.

"I'm pretty sure your hands are nowhere near being small enough to slip through the grate."

"How are we going to—"

An enraged shout comes from behind, "THEY'VE ESCAPED!"

The internal alarms are blaring to trigger my primal flight reaction, while my veins could've caused an earthquake from the tremendous energy surge. "We need to get out of here— NOW!"

I thrust my foot into the grate trusting *all the racket* to cover the sound. I release a breath, luckily the carpet absorbed most of the noise. "Quickly!" I hiss as I lower myself from within the grate. Imperia comes down as I scramble to lock the door, "*click*". I scurry my way over to the window. A sickening feeling stumbles across me. The fall is way too long, I'd guess we are at least 4 stories high. My eyes dart across the room. I notice an enormous roll of ethernet cabling on the ground and I can only hope it will be sufficient. I shove the roll onto it's side, pushing it towards the window. Luckily this is CAT-8 ethernet cables and they should be thick enough to hold our weight. Rushing to the desk in the middle of the room, I take the one end of the ethernet cable and begin tying it around the leg of the desk, tying an extra knot to be safe. A rattling comes from the door.

"Hey! I think they are in here!" shouts a man.

"Imperia, Benjo. Lets Go!" I hiss.

I bolt over to the window. Imperia is already a 3/4 of the way down the cable, while Benjo is in the process of lowering himself through the window.

"I'm coming in!" the man shouts.

My thudding in my chest becomes as rocket speed when the man begins busting down the door! I launch myself through the window nearly losing my grip on the cable. I begin sliding all the way down the line. If I didn't know better I would say my hands were smoking. I already regret sliding before I'm even half way down.

"Agh!" I catch a glimpse of my hands.... blood, blisters from the intense friction.

"THUD, THUD— WHAM!" the door crashes open.

"They're coming!" I shout.

"This way!" shouts Imperia.

Imperia bolts down the ominous alley. We are like rockets behind her, we follow Imperia through the alley and onto a main street. The street was crowded, I nearly lost sight of Imperia while shoving my way through.

"Wait there's NPCs too?" I exclaim.

"Apparently," grumbles Benjo, "Probably here to disorientate us!"

"Just don't stop, we should run for as long as we can," I breath, "the more distance the better!"

Sweat drizzels down my face as we appoarch the boarder. I am about to ask how we are going to go past the wall when I notice the gate is ajar.

"Where in the world are the guards?" I call.

Imperia giggles, "I don't know, but it certainly simplifies our lives."

"Lets go in the forest," Benjo suggests, "I don't like how empty it is here."

I hold my hand up, "Wait... We don't know what could be in there."

"Yeah your probably right," Benjo admits.

"Maybe we could find something to use as weapons," Imperia suggests.

We begin scavenging around for anything we could use.

"Would a this work?" Benjo holds up a big stick.

"It's as good as we're going to get," I call, "Let's see if we can find some others."

Deep within the forest the light becomes slivers.

"Does anyone feel like it's getting darker?" Benjo calls.

"Yeah, it's not only you," I mope, "It definitely is."

"Whoosh!" a rustling from a bush.

"AHH!" Imperia cries.

I throw myself forward without thinking, and I am overwhelmed by an intense stinging as something slimly stabs into my body. My eyes widen when I see an insect-like monster towering above us. My ears are filled with the sound of music and I the world begins fading away.

"Ender—"

No. I'm not going down that easily. With a roar, I throw myself to my feet. I grimace as the world's revolving around me. I give a cry and charge ahead, stick in hand. My face takes on a revolting expression at the squishing noise the impact makes. I collapse seconds before the world falls into darkness.

Chapter C (Cyber Revolution)

A droplet of splashes onto my cheek, "Hang in there Ender! You can't leave us... we need you," Imperia cries.

Lifting my eyelids is a struggle and a moan escapes me. Imperia gasps, "Ender?" A soft warmth slips into my fingers, "I thought we were going to lose you!"

"I guess I go down that easily," I grin.

"No... Ender you saved me! Someone who goes down easily wouldn't be able to save their friends like you did," Imperia insists.

"Hey... I think we should get going," Benjo eyes hover over us.

Imperia lets out a gasp realizing she's holding my hand. The warmth leaves my hand and Imperia's gone flush, "Yeah... we probably should."

With little ease, I push myself onto my feet, "Lead the way Benjo!"

The venture through the forest lasts an eternity. The forest is so dense we have to slow down. The forest takes a turn and breaks into an open field. In the distance is a small hut, smoke rising from its chimney.

I glance towards Imperia, "Someone must be home."

She nods, "Yeah, but should we—"

I collapse to the ground. My legs no longer function. "Help," I croak, "My legs aren't working!"

"Benjo!" Imperia calls, "I'll need your help carrying him. Someone inside the hut could help us!"

Benjo's arms slide underneath me lifting me from the ground. Benjo breaks into something you'd call a sprint while carrying someone. My breathing increases as he sways under my weight closing the distance to the little cabin. My ears are filled with his heavy panting and the thudding of his feet up the wooden steps.

Benjo lowers me onto a worn down wooden bench on the huts front porch, "We'll be back in a moment."

"Tut-tut-tut."

The door creaks open revealing an old man who's hair is white with age.

"Oh!" the man cheers, "Guests? I haven't seen another person in ages, please come in!"

Benjo raises his arm and points towards me and the man lets out a cry.

"Yeah... we sort of figured out the forest isn't the friendless of places," Benjo titters

I am lifted from the bench. The cabin is simple and is composed of only two rooms.

"What happened out there?" the man asks.

"This massive mosquito-like creature attacked us! Ender here was stabbed by its proboscis— the needle in simpler terms," he explains

"Dear heavens! A Mosquitar? We have a problem on our hands," the man paces, "If we don't get the right ingredients in time," the man falters under his own words, "y-your friend could..."

"It's not real!" Imperia bawls, "there's no way... it's a virtual world!"

"So... the world might as well be real," Benjo states.

A nod from the old man confirms, "We better hurry! Beause you really don't want to be out after nightfall."

I groan from the table as the world around me becomes muffled.

"Ender—" the world fades away.

Chapter D Imperia (Cyber Revolution)

Ender! Hang in there!" I sob, "No you can't die... no!"

The old man grabs my elbow, "I urge you to follow me. It's the only way to save him."

The old door creaks before we venture through the depths of the forest.

"What exactly are we looking for?" I ask.

"We'll first, we'll need heathberries. They can only be found deep within the forest and are red in color. They'll neutralize the acid from the injection."

I'll save you Ender... you know I will. A red glimmer catches my eye, "I think I found some!"

Benjo and the old man struggle to keep up.

"Wait! Stop—"

It's already too late. My feet start to burn. "AHH! I look down into a fiery blaze as it surrounds me!" My heart races as the dense smoke squeezes me of air.

"Help!" the scream comes out as a croak.

"I should've warned you."

"Too late for that now," Benjo calls.

The flame morphs as it begins taking on snake-like features before me. It's dark gleaming red eyes scorch holes through my own as the monster takes in a deep breath and tilts its head back.

"Whoosh!" I dive, catching a glimpse of where I had just been standing, blackened by the heat and scorched from the flame.

I exhale, "too close—"

I am knocked from my feet and find arms beneath me.

"AHH!" I scream upon realizing we're about to crash through the flames.

"Mhmmm" Benjo moans.

When my eyes finally adjust I gasp. He's covered in red spots and burns from the risk he took to save me.

"Such a foolish act," the man mumbles.

"Now would be a good time to run," Benjo suggests.

"Wait—" I gasp, "We still need those heathberries!"

"No way I'm going near that thing again," he whimpers before mumbling, "what was the thing anyways?"

"That mister... was a Heathanater," the man answers, "I'll be damned, they're always protecting those berries!"

"How do you expect us to get them?" I blurt.

"A problem indeed," he sighs, "and a wonder why no ones ever dealt with them."

"I'm not taking no for an answer. I need Ender... I-I," my face reddens.

"Is something wrong?" Benjo twiddles with his thumbs.

"No it's just—" I begin, "just don't worry about it okay?"

"For the task at hand." I sharply exhale when I hear him change the subject. "You are 100% sure no ones every achieved this?"

"No doubt in my certain mind," the man winks with a sly glance, "the first, however, is standing right here before me!"

"That's it!" I spout, "We need water!"

"Your a genius!" he makes it sound like anyone could've though of the idea. "Do you happen to have a bucket we could borrow?"

"Yes..." he hesitates, "there's no time!"

The pain grows in my heart. I'm going to penetrate the code this time, I'm coming for you Ender. I manipulate the code with unrestricted speed and swarm the code amidst my ferocious attitude.

A coldness sensation grips my hands as formation of a blue gel sheds its electric blue energy into my palms.

"Whoa! How did you do that?"

"No time for that now," I shout.

"It's about time this dude learns who can't be put out," I chuckle before breaking into a charge.

"Sizzz," the monster lets out a earsplitting scream before giving me an angry hiss and slithering away.

"Yeah!" Benjo jogs over to me for a high five, but jerks his hand away when it contacts mine, "I don't know how you did it!"

I wrap my hand around the scarlet fruit and my hands return to their normal temperatures. We work swiftly because who wants to be here when that thing comes back? Yeah... not me.

"Is that all?" Benjo rubs his hands together.

I stuff a giggle down my throat when I notice he is still freezing from the high five.

"No, there's still one more thing," the man informs, "we'll need something which will react with the health berries."

"Which is," I propose.

"We'll to be honest, I've never really gotten this far. Here's what I know. The traveler will find me where the grass is high and the sun shines dimly below."

"Hmm... is it a place?"

"Could be, I really haven't a clue."

"That's it!" Benjo jumps , "Do you know if there are any swamps nearby?"

The trip takes around 10 minutes. My feet making squishing noises more and more as we close the distance between us and the swamp.

"Look over there!" I point towards what would appear to be a slimy creature.

"Do you happen to have a jar?" I hear Benjo ask.

"Yup! I'm always prepared," the man claims with a smile.

I hold my breath as Benjo approaches the slimy creature. "Please be careful," I whisper under my breath.

Chapter E Ender (Cyber Revolution)

The world comes back and streaks of light squeeze now through the window. I feel much better.

"How'd you do that," I stretch as if I'd just awoken from a long nap.

"We'll for one we almost died," she winks, "second, we managed to mixup an antidote for the injection you got."

"I'll never be able to pay this back," I tease.

"Hmm... I think you already have because having you back is all I—" Imperia blushes.

"She told me not to worry about it," Benjo smirks, "Oh... and you also owe me now— I saved her!" he shows me the burns on his arms.

"Let go of it!" Imperia whines.

I smile, "So what? Lets say I never pay you back Benjo—"

"That'd be 300 more punches added to your list," he quips before breaking into a smile.

"Great, now what am I going to do?"

"If I were you," Imperia winks, "I'd pay him back sometime!"

The old man comes over and greets us with a gift before we leave. "Here are some weapons you can use to defend yourselves," he hands us a bow and a device which appears to be a scanner, "I've had enough experiences in my life and for once, I don't think I'll ever be stepping foot in that forest ever again."

(- - -)

A thin haze covers over us while the trees are dark and eerily rustling in the wind. We warily creep along a ominous path into the forest. Owls are hooting in the distance along with the howling of a wolf.

"Whoosh!" I'm thrust into the air and find myself entangled in a net surrounding me on all side. I've stumbled upon a trap!

With a yelp, I call down to my friends, "Help!" My friends pivot around on their toes feeling chary about the situation.

They're going to need something sharp to cut the net surrounding me. My eyes dart over my surroundings before catching sight of a slight glimmering in the distance, focusing hard on upon the spot I can make out a sword! I call down to my friends, telling them where the sword is. Benjo takes a step and hesitates for a moment before creeping towards the sword. He reaches the sword and extends his arm out to gasps his hands around the hilt of the sword. After one mighty show of heaving, he easily removes the sword from its embedment in the ground. Wielding the sword, he begins journeying back to us. He raises the sword high above his head once he reaches me and then brings it down upon the rope trapping me up in the trees. Next thing I known, I am falling through the air and a great thud indicates my impact with the ground. I climb to my feet stumbling a bit before exchanging a chuckle with Benjo. He keeps the sword since he claims to have the most experience with one. With the extra weapon we begin lurking further down the trail, deeper into the forest.

Further along the path, a dark figure looms from the darkness of a tree and begins rapidly approaching. It isn't long before I can identify him as a wizard. He claims to be alone and is setting up camp for the evening.

"Will you join me?" he asks, "On the ground safety comes in numbers."

We sit down while he sets up his camp and he offers to make us tea.

"What are you doing out here, wondering on your own if it's so dangerous," I ask.

"I am going to visit my son at a local temple," he responds. In this moment I notice something doesn't add up with what he is saying. Because I'm pretty sure there are no temples around.

"We're good," I declining.

"We need to get out of here I whisper into Imperia's and Benjo's ears.

"They avoided near death as the wizard is actually a necromancer, the tea was poisoned."

Our journey continues down the endless path deep into the forest. A owl hoots and birds rustle within the trees around us.

I cough as a cloying mist crosses into our path. I can barely see just five paces ahead of myself. Vague, bulbous forms can be seen protruding from the trees as we are passing — fungus! This isn't mist, its spores!

Fear rushes through me, "RUN!"

We bolt ahead with dazzling speed. Running is hard with such a lack of breathable air. I am just about to collapse when we reach a point where the mist begins to thin. Finally I can breathe.

We continue until we are for sure out of the deadly grasps of the mist. I collapse onto the forest floor sweating and tired from the sprint. It's essential to make sure we have the energy to run again if we have to.

A bush rustles to the left of me and I catch sight of something in the edge of the darkness— A strange creature, about the size of a dog, it has 6 legs and a long, ribbon like tail. Its skin is rough, thick, and covered in thin fluffy gray fur spotted in bronze.

"Benjo, quick! Scan the creature!"

"Uhhh guys look like we have a sabre tooth scourge!" he informs us, "It says here that they are blind and rely on their taste buds and hearing to attack."

"Shh—" Imperia whispers, "Stay quiet!"

Scourges are crepuscular. They rely on their taste buds and hearing to navigate around. Although they do have small, elliptic eyes, their sight is extremely poor. Lacking a visible nose, its ears are enormous in size, while its head relatively small in comparison to its body.

A low growl rumbles from the scourge and it smells us nearby. It begins approaching upon us in a crawl-like manner. We stand closely together with Benjo in front wielding his sword.

The scourge leaps and Benjo's sword comes crashing down. The creature yelps and becomes limp, laying dead on the forest floor.

I begin trembling as we push forward. My desire to abandon the forest intensifies and my desperation to hide in my own safe home is overwhelming. Our surrounding begins radiating and pulsing with an ominous red glow. Even this seems abnormal for the Forest of Unknowns. Ominously, the glow creeps across the forest floor. It's coming right towards us! The thudding increases in my ears as its evilness threatens to engulf us. Crawling from the darkness a creature illuminated in deep red numbers lining along its surface reveals itself.

The device blares an alarm, "Warning, Corrupters imminent! Evacuation recommended!"

This can only mean one thing why else would they call it a Corrupter.

I gasp, "They're literally devouring the code around themselves. They're causing corruption to occur!" I chock "RUN!"

We're all sent springing into vigorous action. The speed that carries us is tremendous as we glide through the air.

We are panting when Benjo screams, "they're threatening to devour us alive! Don't stop!"

After running for what feels like eternity, the evil glow begins to fade and is only darkening with each step. We're getting away! A little further and we collapse into a heap on the ground, heavily panting from a run requiring all of our might!

"Look," Benjo points out another hut with walls rotting heavily and construed of wood.

"Guys," I call, "I don't think this hut is anything like the last, we still need to proceed with caution!"

We are standing at it's front door. I reach my hand down, shaking as I grasp the door handle. It feels unusually cold.

"Are we sure about this?"

They both nod, "it's our best bet. We don't have any other options and the monsters here are way too dangerous during nightfall."

I turn the handle opening the door to its unknowns. Inside the hut it is dark and the floor boards creak under our weight from being ancient in age. I step on something and bend down to pick up the unknown object.

"I think I found flint and steel."

"We can use that to light up this old place," Imperia calls.

My hand bumps against a candle along the wall in the darkness. spot a candle. Hovering my hands above and hoping it's a candle, I strike the flint and steel sending sparks flying with a "crack," followed by a "pop" from the candle being caught by a spark. The candle

ignites and I am able to observe my surroundings. A room occupied by a grand sum of ancient furniture, all of which has its fabric lined by nature. Surely this hut serves a purpose. We all begin investigating in a search for anything peculiar.

"Come look at this!" comes an excited shout from Imperia.

After scrambling to approach the spot Imperia noticed something, I cannot believe my eyes— it's a trapdoor!

I realize what this might mean. Could there be a server room hidden within this game. *No, I won't allow myself to think that way... I'll only lose hope.* In a grand attempt to lift the trapdoor I find it doesn't budge. Then Benjo steps forward and in one motion is bringing his sword down using the blade as a wedge beneath the door for leverage.

"Creeeeaaakk!" the trapdoor pops, revealing an opening in the floor of the hut. A ladder shoots down into its depths where an ominous blue light radiates from the point the trapdoor once stood.

I go first, holding my breath and progressing hand over hand down the ladder. The ladder is long and I am exhausted when I reach the depths below. I briefly check to make sure the coast is clear before giving a mighty shout and singling for Benjo and Imperia to climb on down.

A hazy blue glow and twinkling green lights surrounds me.

"thud," Imperia reaches the bottom, followed moments later by Benjo.

"No way! It's actually a server room!" I exclaim, "Could it really be this easy?"

"Careful," shouts Imperia, "We shouldn't get our hopes up yet."

We begin searching through the ominous server room searching for a console or anything we could hack and leave from this virtual world.

A shimmering light catches my attention, "look it's a screen!"

Benjo and Imperia jog over to me where the screen appears to be scrolling through mass amounts of data. While holding our breath we approach the console board together.

Imperia steps forwards, laying her hands above the keyboard before her fingers become a blur I doubt I could ever follow. Moments pass when Imperia steps back grinning, "I think I've done it!"

Orange and Blue light begins stretching us apart... We did it! *We escap—*

The lights abruptly disappear before a malicious laugh fills the room, "You really thought It'd be that easily... How amusing! We'll now your going to pay for your mistake."

Chapter F (Cyber Revolution)

An unusual red swarms into our vision and the air becomes unbearably hotter.

"Um guys... I think we may have been teleported into a volcano!" Benjo calls.

"It can't be—" I gasp.

"Everything defiantly seems hotter around here," Imperia agrees.

"You said everything's hotter... so that includes—"

Imperia's cheeks flush, "Don't even go there smartiepants!"

"Hey guys.... did you forget we're still inside of a volcano? Stop teasing each other!"

Benjo snaps, "If you don't believe me go take a look over that ledge for yourself."

"I wasn't—"

The volcano releases a roar as if rumbling with rage.

"WE NEED TO GET OUT OF HERE! IT'S GONNA BLOW!"

We make a beeline to higher grounds. The volcano gives another roar engulfing the place we just stood.

"Everyone we're going to have to jump!" Benjo roars, "I'll go first!"

Benjo takes something you'd call a leap of faith and somehow landing on his feet, he crashes onto the other side.

I got next, "Here goes nothing!"

I break into a sprint and land on the other side flat on my butt. "Owe," I cry.

"If I were you I would've landed on my feet and not my butt instead," he jokes.

"Pffph,"you only stayed on your feet because you were a mere foot taller!"

"Maybe, maybe not. Lets help Imperia."

"Ahh!" I scream. A monster forged in the color of lava splatters onto the path ahead.

"RRHHH" it gives us a roar as it spits a glob of lava straight at us! I dive knocking Imperia down in the process just as a burst of heat soars over our heads.

"Thanks,"

"Actually this time it was completely by accident."

"Sure didn't look that way," she throws a quick wink.

"Hey Benjo. Have any Ideas?"

"Nope, I'm drained," he admits, "Oh and you owe me this time!"

"Ugh, Imperia?"

"Not a clue."

Great what will we do? "Hey wait... Benjo you still have that bucket on you?"

"Yes but all this heats drained it of water!"

"Crap. I mean I guess it not like there was going to be enough water anyways."

"Umm guys," Imperia exclaims, "Couldn't we just use the bucket to blind or confuse him?"

"What do you mean?"

"Look it says right here, she holds up the tablet, "Magma's can be killed or evaded using metal. Magma's have developed a taste for metal and by using it as a distraction the traveler should be able to slip by."

"Genius!" Benjo compliments.

I don't know how I ended up with Imperia in my arms, "Just showing how much I appreciate having you!"

"Sure..."

I feel my face grow hot just as another chunk of magma soars overhead.

"Nevermind! But you better tell me the full story later!" she grins as she extends her arms, "The bucket!"

With a flick of his wrist Benjo tosses the bucket and the Magma releases a rageful roar and charges. Just before the last moment Imperia tosses the bucket over the edge and the Magma disappears on with it.

"Nice one!" I give her a high five, "We should get moving before it comes back."

They both nod, "Excellent idea!"

"Hurry!" I shout, "The lava's almost here!" I veer to the left into a narrow passageway. The tunnel is long but it's our best and only chance of escaping this place alive. I glance back to make sure Benjo and Imperia are still right on my heels.

"Faster!" the lava's getting close!" Imperia cries. We run as hard as we can, it's all we can do to stay ahead of the lava.

"Guys!" I exclaim, "I see light!"

"Hopefully it's daylight," Benjo mutters, "because it better not be another volcano!"

"Jump coming up ahead!" I warn just before I take the leap landing onto my feet this time. Benjo comes right behind me, sliding to a halt after me. Then Imperia—

"Ahh!" I spring forward just as Imperia loses her balance, "Yaww!" Heat soars up my leg and I throw us to the other side.

"Ender—"

"Don't worry about it!" I shout, "Just run!"

The pain running through my foot is unbearable, It's all I can do to keep running because if I don't, we'll all know you'd die.

"Hey guys look, a town!" Imperia cries.

I look at our path to the town and my face turns white, "Umm.... sorry to break the excitement but look at our path ahead."

My friends become petrified and dread overtakes their faces. Apocalyptic landscapes surround abroad. It's deeply ominous crimson color express a sense of eeriness. Ghoulish paths wind deeply into its depths.

"We have to do this we can't stop now!" the determinations running through me.

"I guess your right..." my friends say in hesitation as we begin the trek forward.

"Clink, Cling, Clink, Clink", the sounds of someone approaching.

Before us, a Drasm Rider, a knight riding upon a large, unique, quadrupedal creature with an oval head with elongated pronged horns, no eyes, no visible ears, no visible nose, and a sharp, hooked beak filled with flat teeth. It has a wide neck, and its shoulders are drooped. It has a swollen torso. It has two elongated, thick forelegs that end in adhesive pads, two muscular hind legs that end in large paws and a thick tail. The Drasm's head, neck, shoulders and back are covered in scales, while the rest of its body is covered in luxurious fur. It's mostly vivid green, with dark pink sections and dull blue highlights, while its front/underbelly is vivid orange. A knight steps down from its Drasm — equipped with deep crimson armor. "Cling, Cling", the knight is before us. In a sleek move, drawing out its sword, a Volcanic Iron Quickblade. Taking a step forward I wield the sword we obtained earlier.

"Hey," my voice urgent, "Mind if we pass by?"

"No one passes by without a fight," the rider charges forward.

"Clash!" our swords clashing in the air. Benjo comes raises his bow from the side and fires and the knight falls cold on the ground. Screeching, the Drasm trots abroad and we continue to go deeper towards the asylum.

"Great teamwork!" I bump fists with Benjo. "We really could use this sword," I bend down to lift it from the ground— "Ahh it's hot!"

"Only the one who kills its enemy can wield the Volcanic Quickblade," the tablet suddenly speaks.

"Oh, Benjo why don't you try picking it up?"

He bends down to pick up the sword, "Feels just like any old sword to me."

"Now you've made me jealous."

"Guess you should've taken your swing first," he grins.

We are meet by a broad figure appearing from the darkness. I stumble backwards, its sudden appearance startling me.. A Golem, who's eyes are a deep red with malice boiling within.

I am reaching down to pull out my sword when Benjo calls out, "I've got this one!"

The Golem snaps to attention and out comes his Glimmer, the Runed Blade of Giantslaying; forged of a jagged blade, orange radiating from within, dragons and

compasses etched into it. Its guard is circular, the grip, wrapped in black leather. With one mighty roar the golem charges straight towards Benjo. The Golem's sword is mighty and it radiates like flame.

"Actually I might need some help with this one—" he admits and I quickly ready my blade, "Switch!"

I leap forward and heat swarms around me. My sword begins glowing it's becoming white-hot! "Benjo!!" I jump back as metal collides.

Benjo gives a mighty roar and the Golem seemingly ceases from existence.

In a tight stand we continue to push forward noticing the path's condition is improving with every step we take as if leading us to closer to safer grounds.

"Hey look!" I pump my fist into the air, "we made it!"

"Yeah!" Imperia grins!

"We did it!" Benjo howls.

Chapter G (Cyber Revolution)

"Am I the only one who feels like this is a ghost town?" I complain.

"Yeah why are there no people?" Imperia adds.

"Get inside! It's coming, it's coming!" someone shrieks.

"I gotta admit, but this feels worse, " warns Benjo.

"Psst... over hear." i look to my right where a women stands in a door.

"Benjo, Imperia, over here!" I whisper.

She leads us through the door into a room where I can't even see my own hands.

"Watch yourselves, there's a staircase coming up."

We all slow down to a sloths pace slipping our feet forward in an attempt to feel the ledge.

A girl giggles, "You all look so silly doing that!"

"Wait how come you can see us?"

"I only gave my eyes time to adjust!" she giggles again.

After squinting I do indeed find I can see a bit, "Hey you guys can you see now?"

"Yeah!" whispers Benjo.

"Wait— I still can't see!" Imperia whimpers, "And I-I'm scared of the dark!"

I hear Benjo snickering a bit and I give him a nasty glare I'm sure he couldn't even have seen.

I slip my hand into Imperia's, "Here I'll guide you!"

Once we make it down the staircase we find a singular light in the corner. Imperia never lets go of my hand and I can still feel her shaking with fear.

"We're going to be okay. Let me see If I can get them to add another light."

"T-thanks," she shutters.

"Hey ma'am, could we get some more light? My friend here is scared."

"Sorry, won't be possible, "the women frowns.

"Why—"

"Do you not know why we have to be down here in the first place? her voice becomes hoarse, "Every week our town is invaded by a monster who will attack anyone and everyone it can find. I wish we could have more—" She's interrupted when Benjo lights his sword for light.

"Hey! Turn that off, anything brighter than the moon and you'll—"

Imperia screams and I rush over to her. This time she's the one to grab my hand, "What was that—" she never gets to finish because the ground rumbles like an earthquake. Instead she barriers herself into my arms for comfort, "I'm scared."

"I know you are," I try to comfort her, "You have me and you'll be safe as long as I stand in front of you."

"You idiots!" the women screams, "look what you have done! You've brought him right to us!"

The door caves in crashing down the staircase and a gaping hole now stands in the door frame opening the flood gates of a massive heat wave.

"Stay behind me," I command.

I draw my Giant Slayer and take my stance.

"Wait— you didn't tell me you had a Giant Slayer!" the women cries, "With that we'd be able to take that monster on!"

A massive arm crashes down the staircase, except the attack doesn't come at me— "Awhh!" Benjo howls, "my swords not working!"

I don't even think about what I do next and my blade already crashing into the giants arm. I am surprised with the ease the blade takes to slice through the limb.

"ARROOH!" the giant shrieks.

I leap back into action, quickly scaling the limb to end this beast once and for all. I find myself momentarily blinded at the top and I zigzag right and left in an obscured attempt

to dodge it's massive fists. When I am near enough I take a massive swing and the giant crashes to the ground with a roar.

"How did you get that?" the women asks, "With a sword of it's king we could protect our town once and for all!"

"Ahh... One issue, what If I don't want to give it away?" I affirm, "Maybe it's our only weapon and we'll need it."

"I wasn't asking," she smirks, "We'll be taking that sword of yours whether you like it or not."

Benjo throws the women up against the wall, "Call them off or I'm going to kill you."

"Sorry— I wouldn't do that, they'll be some serious consequences if you do," she throws us a evil grin.

I am thrown to the ground while I am distracted by Benjo. I grasp the sword tightly but my strengths no match up against 5 grown men.

"Give it back!" I shout.

"Shut up boi," one of the men rage, "And just to be clear you won't be getting this back." He flashes the sword as a way of showing it off.

"What are you going to do with me and my friends?"

"Ahh... we'll with this kind of attitude, I'd say say we'll be locking you up!" he chuckles, "Wish you would've handed it over then we wouldn't be having this issue."

"You—"

"Ender—" Imperia reaches for my hand, "Don't do this."

I stand down," fine. Lock us up then."

"Good, I've always liked the ones who'll listen," he licks his lips, "Oh and this ones mine." He points towards Imperia, "She's a cutie."

"What NO—" I feel a prick in my arm and I am unable to speak. I've been paralyzed. Great, absolutely great. Eventually the world fades away and everything does black.

* * *

"What? Where am I?" I moan, "And where are my friends. Where's Imperia?"

My wrists feel numb which tells me I am cuffed down. "Crap!" I shout, "When will you be letting us out of here?!"

A evil laugh fills the room from overhead, "Hehe, I vote for never. What do you think?"

I know better than to assume he is asking me because it's clear he can't be.

"We'll at least until I can have some fun with his girlfriend—"

"She's not my girlfriend!" I fume, "At least not yet!"

"Makes no difference to me," theirs that laugh again, "She's a cutie."

"Y-you bastard," I tremble, "You can't do anything without her consent— I'll make sure of it!"

"Aww... whats the baby going to do," he taunts, "He's all locked up!"

"When I get out of here your going to pay for this... You all are!"

But the lines already went silent. I'm not one to curse but what that man's planning to do really makes me want to do it.

"Argh," I groan, "these stupid cuffs!" I scramble to find anything I may be able to use to pick these locks. I find nothing and yelp in defeat. *Imperia, I have to save you.*

The window of my cell door slides open and is replaced with a eye.

"Dinner," whoever it is groans.

A tray is pushed through a flap near the bottom of the door. Luckily the meal's decent. A small loaf of bread and some lettuce.

"Hey— wait!"

"What..."

"Could I please have a fork for my lettuce?" I ask in my nicest voice.

"I don't see why it could hurt..." the man leaves and returns moments later as a fork slips through the flap.

I eat the dinner quickly though I'm sure it will make no actual difference because... well my real body is getting no actual nutrients from this. After I finish I quickly locate the camera within the room and turn my back to it. I hold the fork in one hand while I use the other for the lock.

I am only one the first pin of the lock when the door bashes inwards and a man stomps in, "I should've known!" he yanks the fork from within my hand.

I barely have time to react before a burning sensation runs through my side, "Oh and that's for costing me my job."

I smile to myself because little does he know, but I've managed to snag a key off of his belt and its the one for my cuffs! Now I just have to wait.

* * *

The moment's finally came and I throw the key into the locks of my cuffs relived to hear the click which frees me of the cold bands around my wrists. *I'm coming for you Imperia. I'll save you both!* It must be that day because the place is silent. *Those turdhead's left us to die.* I peek into the cell right next to mine and find it empty. "C'mon," I mumble. I approach the second cellular a while holding my breath. A gasp escapes me when I see Imperia. She looks like she's barely alive. Dark spots hand below here eyes and she's bruised all over.

"Imperia," I whisper and her eyes widen.

"Ender—" I hold my hand up silencing her.

I bend down and twist the locks on both of her cuffs. I am soo surprised by what Imperia does next. Imperia throws me into an embrace and a warmth touches my lips. The moment only lasts a few mere seconds but it communicates more than words ever could in that time. I hate breaking this moment and I lean towards her ear, "We need to find Benjo and get outta of here!"

"She quietly nods and we separate. *We have to find him. I know we will.*

Chapter H | Escape the Jail (Cyber Revolution)

We find the room Benjo is being detained.

"Imperia, can you release him?" I toss her the keys, "I'll keep watch at the door."

"Not good," she mumbles, "the key doesn't fit—"

"Wait what?!"

"Yup, they must have expected something like this would happen."

"Yeah and now they want us to choose between saving ourselves at the sake of our friend's or they'll want us to stay here and die with him," I kick the ground, "they knew I couldn't bear leaving a friend nor would I forgive myself."

"Why don't we just pick the locks?" Benjo suggests.

"There couldn't be enough time for it."

"Then why don't we slice the chains off?" he gestures, "I saw them take my sword somewhere over there."

"Good idea except for one thing. Remember how your sword produces light?" Well guess what it'll take to cut the shackles— heat!"

"Hey, I have an idea!" Maybe we could help out the giants—"

"You're crazy! You think those dudes are going to accept our help?" Benjo cries.

"Yeah, I think he's right... I mean we sort of killed one of their kind."

"Do you guys think you could give me a moment?" I insist, "I'll be back in a few moments."

"Wait— I'm coming with you!"

"No." I state, "I'll have to be quick. I have to do this one alone."

"O-okay," Imperia quickly gives me a hug, "Just don't die," she weeps in a whisper, "I don't know if I'll be able to live on without you."

Benjo was right. They did indeed place his sword somewhere over here. I pick up Benjo's blade and creep down the hall. My face brightens— a locker room! Maybe I'll find a spare set of cloths, then they'll only think I'm another guard.

The room's not too large and I'm suprised to find only a few lockers here and there. The first two I open come up empty, but on my third try I hit the jackpot. The locker is empty except for a faded grey outfit, and I assume they must be someones cloths for wearing after duty. I pull the worn pair of pants on and I yelp as I pull the shirt over my head. Guess I never really hit the jackpot then.

The smell of the shirt is revolting, Does this dude even shower? I ask myself.

I only have to find a way into that bunker now that I am all set. I wonder if this place has a ventalation system, because I 100% guarentee the main doors are locked at this point. I do an investigation of the room and pump my first in silient selebration at my find. It's a grate and even better it's blowign cold air which means surely it is a ventelation shaft. Carefully I lift the grate from the ground as any noise from here would only raise suspisions. I extend my arms out and lower into a crouch while my hands reach for the ledge. With ease, I slowly lower myself down into the shaft with the sword slinged across my back. The travel down the shaft begins to worry me and I am unable to progress any faster than a sloth. Even a single noise and my covers blown.

Someone mutters, "I'll bet 500 they'll never leave this place without their friend."

I feel my face retort in disgust... really they're betting on us too... yuck! I continue on until I find a room which is quiet. I wrap my finders around the grate and cautiously life it from it's place and allowing me to drop down.

I land softly on the ground and readjust the sword under my shirt which is becoming extremely discomforting.

Now for the hard part, because for this to work I'm going tot have to give a child this sword and it feels like such a wrong thing to do.

Eventually, I locate a child who seems to be alone and I whisper, "I got something cool for you," I hold up the sword.

"No way! That's awesome," the kid grins and it feels as if a dagger has been strung through my heart. It's hard even though I know this world isn't reality.

I hold my finger to my mouth, "all yours!" I add, "bout' time we started training some new warriors."

I walk briskly and the ping of guilt is almost too much to bare and my heart is already deeply regretting what I have done. *It* was necessary, I tell myself though it doesn't make me feel any better.

"AROAR" the screaming begins. I rush around the stampede dodging the bodies rushing against me. I spot a guard and I purposely collapse into his arms, "save us" I force myself to cry, "o-or the giants are going to tear us all apart!" I wail.

"Sir," his voice is firm, "everything's going to be alright—"

He's interrupted by a sudden shout, "A child's been found with a sword and it's burning with light!"

The guard says nothing else before he begins sprinting after the voice. I smirk to myself... soon he's going to realize I've gotten all of his keys.

(- - -)

I'm out of breath when I come spiriting back into the cellar.

"Here!" I toss the keys.

"One of those should work," I gasp, still in desperate need of air.

"I got it!" the locks click. "Quick, let's get outta here!" She helps Benjo to his feet and we spring through the door.

"This way!" I call, "There's another weapon."

I stand in front of the table where I found Benjo's sword and reach over to grab our original blade.

"Hey—" Benjo whines, "where's my sword."

"I'll have to tell you later," I breathe, "no time to explain now."

We run down another hallway after veering a corner.

"Right now—"

Our passage is blocked by a monster... of course it has to be a gaint!

"STOP! Turn back around!"

We all do a 360° on our heels.

"There's no way we're out running that thing," Benjo pants, "I mean we already can barely breath!"

"This way then!" I detour into another room. What I did was a complete gamble and were lucky it payed off. On the other side of the room is a window.

"An exit!" I gasp, pointing towards the window, "Get it open. I'll try to hold the door as long as I can."

Something hard slams into the door and I my feet leave the ground,

"E—"

"It's open," Benjo cheers.

I push myself off the ground and every bone aches so painfully I'm sure they've all snapped into bits. I struggle to push myself through the window and if it wasn't for Benjo being there to pull me through, I don't think I would've made it. Great, and now I owe him again.

"Run!" I croak through the pain, "We'll need some distance to protect us!"

(- - -)

"Aggh!" I moan, "Guys I need to stop!"

I collapse to the ground.

"Ender!" Imperia drops down next to me, "what happened?"

"Well to be honest, I'm sure I don't have a single bone intact anymore," I groan, "that giant turned me into a rocket!"

I try to make a joke out of it; however, Imperia's too worried for me to find it funny.

"Oh!" she gasps, "What happened to your back! You've got cuts and burns all across it." Her eyes widen, "and why are they in the shape of a sword!"

At that Benjo comments, "Oh and what happened to my sword," he looks like he's about to give me a elbow, then remembers how hurt I already am.

"About that..." I speculate, "I sort of gave it away to a kid—"

"You what!!" his eyes go wide, "dude that was my sword, not yours to give away!"

"Calm down," Imperia steps in, "I'm sure he did it because it was the only way he was going to be able to save you."

"Hmph," he pouts, "I guess your right."

He winks, "But now you owe me a new sword too!"

"Oh please!" I groan, "I should've just left you behind."

"Fine!" he whimpers, "you win!"

"Now with that solved," Imperia points out, "what are we going to do now? We've only got a single weapon and nowhere to hide."

"We're fine right now," Benjo responds.

"Yes... we are right now," she points up towards the sun, "But I'd like to see what you think when night time falls."

"Sorry buddy," I apologize, "Because I'm on her side this time!"

"Hey look it's another town," Benjo calls after climbing to higher grounds, "I bet if we are fast we'll make it before the worst of it all."

"Wait..." I interrupt, "you seriously want to go to another town after all that?"

"Doesn't matter," he drones, "it's the only other place resembling something remotely like a shelter."

The journey to the next town is farther than it looks. We barely make it to the outskirts of town when nightfall decided to come.

"And your sure about this?" Imperia urges.

"It's either there," she points to the town, "or we could become meals for our friends out there," she points into the darkness of the forest.

"We'll when you put it that way," he pauses, "the town definitely sounds better."

"Yeah I'd rather take my chances in the town myself too," I add, "We might even be able to find some new weapons to use in there."

We are relieve when we find this town to be pumping with action. It's way more preferable to the feel of the ghost town were in earlier.

A women comes over to greet us, "Welcome to, Fires Town!"

We greet the women and she offers to be our guide, "you know we don't get to many visitors around here."

"That's not a surprise, I mean it's gotta be 105° out here!" I grin.

"The women laughs, "yeah, I think your right!"

"We are going to need new weapons," I gesture towards my friend, "the town next door sort of stole ours."

"Well, we are known for our markets variety of weapons," she smiles, "Do you have any money?"

"No," I frown, "we just got here a few days ago."

"I think I can help with that," she implies, "because most of our merchants aren't experienced enough to gather resources. There's been an abudence of shortages lately, ya'll known."

The women leads us to a store and the sign reads, "Apprentices Supplies." A chime sounds when we enter the shop where a man stands behind a register.

"Hey Felster," he calls.

"These guys wanna make you a deal," she points to us.

"They are newcomers and don't have a single penny."

The man raises his eyebrows, "what use could you be to me?"

"We'll we've heard the town's been in shortage of supplies and we have the skills to survive in the wilderness here," Imperia explains, "we are in need of new weapons, but without a dime, I don't think we'll be getting what we need."

"Yeah, hmm.. I have been shorthanded on a few supplies lately," he admits, "and if you really know what you are doing, I have a few I need to collect."

"We'll get those supplies," Benjo says in determination.

"Great," he holds up 5 fingers, "I'll pay you this much."

"Wow that's a lot," I add, "Are those resources really worth that much?"

"You'd be surprised!" he reaches under the desk, "If I'm understanding this correctly, you've lost most of your weapons," he tosses us a sword, "take mine for now. It should be strong enough to protect you from the monsters."

(- - -)

So the man wants us to gather him a few firenuts. I have no clue why they are useful, since the man hardly told us why he needed them. The other thing he wanted is the dangerous part— Dragon Scales. At least he told us they are commonly used to produce strong armor.

"Now comes the hard part, because we are going to be stealing some scales from a dragon, who I'm sure is friendly.

"Which way do we need to go?" Imperia asks.

I pull out the map the man gave us, "It should be down that way," I point to the east.

"Hey Ender, I don't like the way that path looks."

They way were supposed to go is blocked by a tremendous trench. I observe the terrain and locate the mouth of a cave embedded in the ground not to far from us.

"Guess we're going down there," I point down at the cave, "or we can enjoy a nice walk."

Both ways have there own set of risks, if we go into a cave we risk getting lost and well taking the long way means we'd probably have to make our way back during nightfall.

"I vote for the cave," Benjo points, "I don't think I have it in me for a marathon walk."

"I say we go around," Imperia counters, "Oh and don't forget, I'm scared of the dark..."

"Just stay close to me then. I'll protect you."

The cave gives off an ominous vibe the deeper we venture and then there's these weird crystal like formations. I have a feeling they are not natural in this case.

"Hey Ender," Benjo crouches in front of one of the crystals and breaks it away from the ground.

"Yuck," he recoils, dropping the crystal, "I don't think I want to know what that is anymore," he smells his hands, "my hands smell disgusting now too!"

"Dude please don't tell me that stuffs excrement."

"Well buddy," he calls, "It's poop."

"D-does," Imperia trembles, "that mean we're not alone down here?"

As if on cue, a growl reverbs through the cavern and Imperia leaps behind me, grasping onto my shoulder. Her eyes are almost level with my shoulder and shes trembling like an earthquake.

A alarm sounds from my pocket, "Warning death imminent! This monster will well overpower your weapons!"

"RUN!" then I realize that's not going to be an option. The way we came in has disappeared. It turns out the path was never a path at all. We just walked into the monsters mouth!

"No, stop!" I tremble, "I think we are inside of it's mouth!"

"Eww," Benjo makes a face, "please don't tell me—"

I sigh, "Yes, Benjo he's going to crap you out."

"That's disgusting!" Imperia recoils.

"Yeah it is," I add, "ready for the time of your life?"

Chapter I | The Belly (Cyber Revolution)

"Guys over here! I point towards an opening at the rear of the cave.

The opening leads into the monsters stomach. The stone walls the stone walls

Lining the cave are now a deep red color. I wouldn't

Call it red it's more of red-grey mix.

"Hey watch out for the liquid," I warn, "I think it's acid!"

The ground is no longer only stone and a black almost tar-like substance covers the ground. Floating in the middle are stones like Ice floating down a river. I prepare myself to leap to the closest stone. I almost fall off when the stone tilts from my weight and I lose my balance. I leap to the next stone which of course does the same. The difference this time is I'm prepared for it. I proceed to the 3rd jump and the ground doesn't lean under my weight which can only mean one thing... I've made it across. I find myself gasping for air. I concentrating so hard on making the jumps I never even realized I didn't breathe a single time jumping across. My friends cross Imperia goes next and safely makes it across and Benjo follows shortly after.

"I don't even want to know what'd happen if you fell into that stuff," he adds, "I mean the pH level on that stuff has to be insane! Do you guys know of an acid strong enough to dissolve solid rocks?"

"Looks like we have a volunteer!" I smile, "Go ahead and jump in!"

"Wait what?!" he exclaims, "How about I'll jump in if you do!"

"Why do I have to jump in? I'm pretty sure you were the one who just volunteered!"

"Just because I was curious doesn't mean I'll jump in and see for myself!"

"Okay guys enough with the teasing," Imperia steps in, "Have you forgotten we are trapped inside of a massive cave monster?"

"Hey," I tease, "you only want out because it's dark in here!"

"It's not the darkness!" she glares.

"I look to Benjo for help, "It's pretty obvious. If it wasn't the darkness then you wouldn't have gotten so annoyed."

"Yup! It's totally the darkness!" he grins.

"Ugh," she moans, "I see how it is!" She mocks, "I'd never knew you enjoyed being eaten so much!"

"Hey we're just having fun!" I grin, "It's nice seeing you join in on the fun!"

"What?!" She pokes me, "If your going to be that way... I wanna see you name at least one person who enjoys being trapped inside of monsters!"

I gag when I find the next room is even worse. The smell's so nauseating I'm almost sure I'll going to be passing out within the next few minutes.

"There's our may out!" I point to the opening at the back of the room, "Let's hurry because one more minute in here then it's all coming up!"

At that moment a slimy green creature shaped like a pill slithers into our path.

"Ahh! Get me away from that thing," Imperia shrieks.

"Hey it's nothing to worry about and it's only just one," try to comfort her.

"You know I'm pretty sure that's gut bacteria. It's just usually large," Benjo states the obvious.

"So t-that things inside of me too?"

"Yup and you hove millions of other bacteria's all over you. Some are good and others are—"

I stop him with a nasty glare, "Dude she's already trembling! Now's not the time for all your science talk. Your even making me uncomfortable!"

"Okay! okay!" he raises his hands into the air, "I'll stop. But you didn't have to be so rude!"

I ignore his comment not wanting to argue. All I want to do right now is make sure she gets out of here first.

"I'm sure we can just walk past it. We should be fine as long as we don't step on it's flagella."

My plan works until Imperia loses her balance and accidentally does what I hoped we wouldn't do. She shrieks when the monster begins chasing her.

"Imperia!" I shout, "Come back over here!" But it's not use and shortly after she trips and the bacteria climbs on top of her. I throw myself across the room angry in many more in the process. When I cross the distance I latch onto the creature with my hands and it feels disgusting. I can only image what Imperia is going through right now. I pull the creature and it's much heavier than I imagined. With a bit of effort I manage to heave the creature off of her. Imperia's not moving and I don't have enough time to check her pulse so I crouch down to lift her up. After I have her in my arms I turn around to find myself surrounded. Then one of the monsters goes limp and a face peeks up from behind it.

"Thought you could use a little help!"

Benjo takes down another one of them and I squeeze through the small gap between the two. I shiver when the slime brushes up against my skin.

"Let's get outta here before they notice their dead friends!"

He does a 360 on his heels and I chase after him as quickly as I can. Of course the worse happens and I hear the slimy sound moving across the stone.

"Crap! I think they're onto us!"

Before I can even blink I feel the wind of Benjo passing by me.

"I'll hold them off for as long as I can!" he urges, "Get her to safety! I'll be right behind you!"

I close the distance faster than I even knew I could. I push forward and a small gap forms in the wall. I thrust myself and Imperia through the hole. I turn myself so I can take the fall on the other side. I almost immediately regret my decision. We make contact with the ground and I yelp. Moments later another form crashes through the opening.

"Are you guys okay?" his face worried.

"I think I'll survive," I reach down to place two fingers against her wrist, "It's her I'm more worried about."

"Does she have a pulse?"

"Yes it's weak but it's definitely still there, "I think she just fainted... Who could blame her? I don't think I could've handled that thing on top of me either.

"Yeah your right," he looks down, "Those things were disgusting!"

I thought I caught movement out of the corner of my eye and I turn my attention back to Imperia. Please wake up I pray as I lance my fingers into her hand and whisper, "I need you."

As if she could hear me she stirs and her eyes pop open.

She squeezes my hand and whispers into my ear "We're not trapped inside anymore are we?"

I nod, "Yeah it's a long story!" I add sarcastically, "You could say I stepped on a few to many coming to save you!"

"Really? If that's true then how did you make it out alive?"

I gesture towards Benjo who's now trying to clean the slimy goo from his shoes, "I had a master of swords backing me up!" I squeezed her hand, "I'd do it all over again for you!"

She moves her eyes over my face and then gazes into my eyes. She squeezes my hand tighter and then does her best to wrap her arms around me. I wrap my arms around her and feel her breath brushing across on my face. I am overwhelmed by with warmness when leans in and kisses me. The moment's over before I know it and she moves her hand back into mine, "And I would do the same for you!"

"Are you done yet?" Benjo groans.

My face gets warm and I glance over to see Imperia's gone red too. I'd almost completely forgotten he was here, "You we're watching?"

"Not really," he grins, "that's why I asked if you were done. It's been pretty obvious you like each other."

"Let's get those dragon scales," I suggest trying to change the subject.

"Okay! But your forgetting one thing, he states the obvious, "we still have to find our way through the rest of this cave!"

Chapter J | Goblins and the Dragon (Cyber Revolution)

We come to a point where the cave branches off.

"Which way should we go?" Imperia asks.

"Well an old friend of mines always says to go left we in doubt," Benjo suggests.

"Really is that so?" She jokes, "Because I've always thought right was the right way to go!"

"Very funny," he chuckles.

We venture into the path on the left. Soon I am able to hear other noises deeper within the darkness.

"Does anyone else hear that noise?"

"Yeah," he answers, "It's sounds to me like a pickaxe. Which means there can only be people living down here!"

"AHH!" Imperia shrieks when a dark form darts in front of us.

Then something pokes me from behind and I almost jump out of my skin. My ears are filled with the sound of someone relentlessly laughing.

"What's going—" he yelps, "Ahh! What is that thing?"

I look over and see a green stature form up in Benjo's face. The creature appears to be grotesque. It's also very sneaky.

"Hahaha," the creature giggles clearly amused to have frighten us.

"Who are you?" I ask.

"Oh me?" the goblins voice is high, "I'm a goblin from the Grotto Tribe!"

"What's the Grotto Tribe?" I ask.

The goblin brings his hands together, "new to these lands I see! Well there are 3 tribes of goblins, the Volcablins, the Grottos, and the Timblins!"

"Grottos sounds like a word similar to cave," I begin, "So does that mean you live in the caves?"

"You got it!" he exclaims, "Volcablins are from the volcanos and Timblins come from the forests."

"How do you guys survive down here," Imperia speculates, "I mean there isn't any food down here is there?"

"Actually there is!" the goblins grins, "We only inhabit the lush caves so there is plenty of vegetation to provide us with food."

"So do you guys ever go up to the surface?" Benjo asks.

"Not at all!" the goblin cries, "No one's every returned from the surface to tell the tale! Some believe the world above is guarded by a fierce dragon —"

"Wait," I interrupt, "Did you just say a dragon?"

"Yes... but it's only a theory," he adds, "Which doesn't mean it's true."

"We'll actually that's just what we are looking for," I inform, "I'm thinking you may be able to help us!"

"What?! Are you insane?!" he exclaims, "I said no one's ever survived to tell the tale! There could not even be a dragon!"

"Okay then... where is the closest exit to the surface?"

"Fine..." he sighs, "I will take you to the surface— but only on one condition. Many years ago the sword of our tribe was lost deep within a dungeon. We have been unable to retreat it because the dangers are just too great."

"Okay..." I pause, "I'm sure it won't hurt if we give it a try."

No it's my turn to have go crazy on me.

"Are you Insane Ender?!" Imperia cries, "I mean we could die in that dungeon!"

"Calm down. Without this goblin's help we're going to be stuck down here for awhile."

She pouts, "Fine," then adds, "but if we die your going to pay for your mistake. I'll make—"

"I'd like to see you try when your dead," I wink, "Last time I checked I'm pretty sure ghosts went right through you!"

"The statement was rhetorical." She giggles, "You didn't need to be such smartie pants."

We have been following the goblin for around 5 mins now. A little further and the cave opens its mouth leading us into to a gigantic cavern. The cavern is lush and green with vegetation.

"Wow this is amazing," Imperia exclaims, "It's absolutely beautiful!"

"Wait until you see the town," the goblin grins, "you only seen the least of it!"

The town is even more amazing and it's illuminated by lights casting a brilliant glow. If I had to answer I'd say this town has around 100 occupants. It's nowhere near the biggest of towns I've seen. If you asked me I would say it's by far more amazing.

"Whoa..." Benjo says in awe, "this place is amazing!"

"Ahh yesi warned for it would be cool!" the goblin reaches to poke him, "maybe you should pay better attention next time!"

Benjo leans towards me to whisper into my ear, "Dudes really pulling for my other side. He's trying to get on my nerves."

"Heard that!" he shouts back towards us again."

The Goblin leads us to the center of the town where an intriguing castle stands. Inside we find the walls to be plated in gold and the floor must be made of pure quartz. The middle rests a beatifully designed fountain running water as clear as a crystal. Behind the fountain is a throne filled by a little green form.

"who are these newcomers who hone set Foot in the lands of Grotto? "the voice bans surprising loudly for such a small form."Your stoneness, "the goblin informs, "they came looking for a dragon."

"Your kidding!" he bellows, " Ha! No ones ever returned to tell that one!"

"No it's not a joke..." I correct, " we'll actually be traveling into dragon your mentioning. mind telling me where it is?"

"Are you crazy?! you'd die!!" he shrieks, " I will on only one condition. If you can recover our sword then I will lead you to the dragon."

We are brought to a small building.

"Welcome to the hotel of Grotto." A desk is situated in front of us and a female gobbbs stands behind it. I have to duck down to inside the building to keep from bonging my head.

"Oh! Guest?" the goblette jumps, " I haven't seen one of your kind in ages!"

"Don't mind her giddishness," he leads us down a tunnel and gestures for us to enter a room, "You know ever some the law closed access to the world above we haven't seen many of your kind."

The room is astounding. It's so much more than you'd ever expect to see in such a place. the Room is made up shiny white crystals and its not just any crystal it's soild quartz. Lining the stone wall of the room are 3 cots, one for each us.

Chapter K | Dragon (Cyber Restricted)

Chapter L | Rewards (Cyber Restricted)

We return to the town 3 days later. Those 3 days were the most terrifying days I'e had in this world if you would've asked me. As we walk through the town I get the feeling something isn't quite right. Why is no one pacing the streets? The situation seems oddly familiar, but I'm also curious as to why and we continue making our way towards the merchant's shop. As we walk down the paths of the town I begin noticing the only ones around are the merchants in their shops. Where did everyone go?

We enter the shop where we met the merchant who gave us our quest.

"Oh there you are!" he exclaims, "I thought we'd lost you for good!"

"Yeah it's a long story," I sigh, "where did all the people go?"

"Oh I forgot you've been gone the past few days," he sighs, "a war has begun."

I gasp, If this world's breaking out into wars could that mean the real world is too? I shake the thought from my head.

"What should we do?" Benjo asks.

"If I were you, I'd get as far away from here as I can," he adds, "I also don't think money will do you any good anymore, you said you needed weapons but the towns pulled them from the shelves for all of our warriors. It's been tough for me, but I've decided to let you keep those swords as payment instead. It's the best I can do."

The news hits me really hard because I really wanted to look through his stash of weapons.

"Thanks," I sigh, "I understand the difficulties you've tried hard enough to help us already."

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We are back in the wilderness again. The land ahead sucks the air from within our lungs. I choke on the air's dryness. The land ahead bares an extremity of sand. Saying it's any cooler here than it was in the volcano realm would be an extreme under estimate. Even though the air is cooling as the sun heads down, I worry